



Culturally - Historically Responsive Mini-Unit
EDU 498: Literacy Learning as Social Practice
Warner School of Education, University of Rochester
Summer 2024
Eric Soublet

Unit Context:

11th and 12th grade ELA class of predominantly Black and Brown students, including ELLs and students with varied learning abilities. The disciplinary focus of the unit will be to strengthen students' literacy skills across multiple modalities through the exploration of counternarrative and mythology. This unit is designed for face-to-face, high-tech, multimodal instruction relying on the flexibility of Ed Tech and digital media to respond to and enhance the diversity and dynamism of the classroom. This unit assumes each student has a district-issued computer with access to Canva, Google Classroom, and Padlet.

Unit Description and Purpose:

The guiding principle of the unit is the idea that cultivating radical imagination through art and mythology can create opportunities for the construction of new narratives that extend beyond the harmful and essentialized ones produced in the dominant discourse. This cultivation of literacy and genius is necessary for students to transcend the roles and outcomes that have been pre-determined for them by society. The essential questions of the unit are:

- How are art, language, and technology used to construct narrative in the world around us?
- What is the role of imagination and mythology in the production of narrative?
- How can students use imagination and mythology to construct counternarratives that disrupt deficit discourses?

In this unit students will investigate the representation of marginalized people throughout the history of the production of images via painting, cinema, photography, and any other mediums students may want to explore. Students are encouraged but not compelled to explore work that uses mythology to imagine new possibilities for people who have been historically oppressed, e.g. Afrofuturism.

Setting the underrepresentation of Black and Brown curators in cultural museums as a premise, students will be asked to step into the role of curator themselves, and curate a virtual gallery or exhibition of their own as well as create accompanying curatorial materials such as audio tours, catalogues, wall texts, social media posts, etc.

Literacies Framework:

The unit will address each layer of the Culturally and Historically Responsive Literacy framework in the following ways:

Identity: Students will learn to look critically at works of art, and interpret connections between art, history, and identity.

Commented [ac1]: Articulate and ambitious

Commented [ac2]: this point is a little underdeveloped. What does the HRL framework tell us is essential in pursuit of identity? right now it lacks specificity, there is limited personal connection and lacking empowerment. I will revisit this in your final feedback

Skills: Students will demonstrate *print authority* by being able to describe the relationships between the pieces that they chose as well as sharing their own critiques and opinions of works of art through curatorial investigation.

Commented [ac3]: nice!

Intellect: In curating a gallery of images and artifacts that represent counternarratives, students will imagine futures on their own terms uninhibited by the constraints of oppressive ideologies projected onto them by media and society.

Criticality: Students will build critical literacy skills while identifying ways that the dominant discourse essentializes their reality and restricts their potential for actualization.

This unit addresses several forms of literacy, including visual, digital, and print. However, the broader intellectual pursuit of the unit is the cultivation of critical literacy. Muhammad writes:

In short, teaching criticality helps students assume responsibility for the ways in which they process information — to avoid being passive consumers of knowledge and information. (Muhammad, 122)

Curators directly influence representation and narrative in major cultural institutions all over the world, in both physical and virtual spaces. By inviting students to take on this role, they become active participants in the sharing of knowledge and construction of narrative, while gaining real insight into how meaning and context can shift according to how information is arranged and displayed, and by whom.

The “global village” imagined by Marshall McLuhan (1968) is fact: a virtual and material world where traditional print and image, canonical genres, and new modalities of information sit side by side—where new and old media build discourse communities and enable political and cultural action.

Muhammad, G., & Love, B. L. (2020). Cultivating genius: an equity framework for culturally and historically responsive literacy. New York, NY, Scholastic Inc.

Allan Luke (2012) Critical Literacy: Foundational Notes, Theory Into Practice, 51:1, 4-11, DOI: 10.1080/00405841.2012.636324

Name of Lesson: Curators of Color: “Responding to the local”	
Teacher: Mr. Soublet	Grade Level: 11/12
Length of Lesson: This lesson could be completed over 3, 50-minute class periods	

Name of Lesson: Curators of Color: “Responding to the local”	
Students’ Identities and Background: Predominantly Black and Brown, multiracial, multiethnic, multilingual students of varying learning abilities from challenged, low-resource communities.	
Learning Goals	Identities: Students will learn about the role of <i>Curator</i> in cultural institutions and the underrepresentation of BIPOC in these roles. The teacher will pose the question of how this disproportionality might impact narratives and perceptions of BIPOC people in the arts and by extension the society at large, especially in the students’ local community. Skills: Students will learn central vocabulary terms <i>curate</i>, <i>context</i>, <i>narrative</i>, and <i>counternarrative</i>, and look at other example uses of the affix <i>counter-</i>: <i>counterculture</i>, <i>counteroffensive</i> Intellect: Students will become smarter about the relationships between culture, identity, and power. Criticality: While investigating these relationships, students will be prompted to think about how the role of a curator can directly impact their local community, both positively and/or negatively. Joy: Art is beautiful and exciting and brings so much joy into people’s lives. Students will not only be encouraged to approach the project centering joy and beauty, but also to think about how curators can enhance accessibility to joy and beauty in their roles.
Layered Texts	Global Blackness and the Legacy of Arturo Schomburg These Museum Curators are Changing the Way We Look at Art Black Bronzeville Curators Create Fortunehouse, an Art Space for the Community
Vocabulary & Concepts	Central Vocabulary: Curate

Commented [ac4]: Beautiful!

Commented [ac5]: Wow he was a legend! Also crazy that he was a Mason- considering the history of racial discrimination in the organization.

Name of Lesson: Curators of Color: “Responding to the local”	
	• context • representation • narrative • counternarrative Central Concept: “responding to the local” <i>“My curatorial practice is responding to the local and wanting to think about socio-political issues that affect people in my city...I haven’t felt beholden to an art historical trajectory. I did not go to art school; I don’t have an art-historical background or a curatorial background in the academic sense. I’m really just responding to culture and the things that are around me” - Erin Christovale, Curator – Hammer Museum, Los Angeles</i>
Student Spark	The teacher will introduce the final project and explain how students curate every day: how you dress, what you choose to say or show about yourself, what you post on social media, music playlists, etc. The teacher will explore with the students the social media accounts of contemporary archivists, curators, and artists such as: Guadalupe Rosales (Veteranas And Rucas) Liz Johnson Artur (Photographer) Erin Christovale (Curator) Students will be invited to share any artists or curators they know and are excited about. The teacher will introduce the questions: • How can a curator directly impact a community? Positively? Negatively? • As a curator, what kind of work would you want to show your community? What would you want to say to or with your community?
Body of Lesson	The teacher will facilitate a guided exploration of the role of curator and how identity, power, and representation are

Name of Lesson: Curators of Color: “Responding to the local”	
	negotiated in cultural institutions which have been historically White, male, European, heterosexual spaces. The teacher will provide examples of historical and contemporary BIPOC curators using video artifacts. The teacher will then introduce the central vocabulary of the unit to begin empowering the students to talk about and analyze works of art. Finally, the students will be asked to create a draft of a curatorial proposal, outlining an issue facing their communities that they may want to address for their curatorial project and what medium/s of art they would be interested in exploring these issues through and why. This proposal will begin to form the basis of the students’ curatorial statements.
Closure	The teacher will ask students to share their rough proposals to the class so that students can begin building off of each other’s ideas.
Assessment	Students will be assessed on their proposals according to: • How the issue the student aims to address is connected to their identities. • How clearly the student is able to explain why they have chosen the local issues that they have, and the medium of art through which to explore it. • Does the proposal address the relationships between culture, power, and identity? • What is the dominant narrative? What is the proposed counternarrative? • How does the student sees themselves incorporating joy into this project?

Commented [ac6]: how will you assess this - how do you scaffold your own understanding of students identities in order to do this?

Name of Lesson: Myth and Meaning-making or Culture in Freefall (Jafa)	
Teacher: Mr. Soublet	Grade Level: 11/12
Length of Lesson: This lesson could be completed over 2, 50-minute class periods	
Students' Identities and Background: Predominantly Black and Brown, multiracial, multiethnic, multilingual students of varying learning abilities from challenged, low-resource communities.	
Learning Goals	Identities: Students will be asked to think about storytelling practices in their family or community and how these stories and the modalities with which they are told, authentic expressions of their identities. Skills: Students will learn central vocabulary terms: <i>Afrofuturism</i>, <i>myth</i>, and continue to explore curatorial language and texts to help them Intellect: Students will look at how an artist's choice of medium and material can communicate meaning (Brackens and cloth, Walker and silhouette, El Anatsui and liquor, etc.) and consider how objects and materials can have sociopolitical, historical, even racial connotations. Understanding that these associations can shift according to the context within which the objects are placed is a key takeaway for the student that will prepare them for the final project. Criticality: Using Deidrick Brackens' piece <i>bitter attendance</i>, <i>drown jubilee</i> and the Afrofuturist mythology of Detroit techno duo, Drexciya, students will learn ways in which artists from marginalized communities have attempted to use mythology as a way to make meaning of and alter painful and traumatic realities — and histories. Joy: The conceptual centerpiece of this lesson is the alchemical practice of creating joy and beauty out of pain and trauma as an act of defiance, and survival, in the face of violence and oppression. What Athur Jafa describes as <i>creating culture in freefall</i>.

Name of Lesson: Myth and Meaning-making or Culture in Freefall (Jafa)	
Layered Texts	Short documentary about Drexciya (Afrofuturist techno duo, Detroit) “If you are Afro-American, and you are in a country where your relatives were not able to practice the culture where they were from, because they were slaves brought over from Africa, you adapt in other ways. You re-create your universe. It was done a long time ago out of necessity to stay sane in an insane world” – Jeff Mills (DJ, Producer & Composer, Detroit) Hammer Museum Article about Diedrick Brackens– Made in LA (2018) “Thoughtfully employing the language of weaving and textile making, Diedrick Brackens explores the intersections of identity and sociopolitical issues in the United States. Brackens uses calculated woven algorithms that stem from the cultural histories of African, American, and European textiles to generate his intricate tapestries, seeking to highlight the complexities of African-American identity while also focusing on the loom and its significance to cultural production.” Diedrick Brackens discussing his artistic practice “[thread] it’s a material that I think people have specific associations with —comfort, healing — a lot the things that I try to talk about deal with healing or care”
Vocabulary & Concepts	Central vocabulary: • Afrofuturism • myth • medium Students will explore the concept of mythology as a modality for meaning-making through which oppressed people can author alternative futures for themselves.

Name of Lesson: Myth and Meaning-making or Culture in Freefall (Jafa)	
Student Spark	The teacher will introduce the Virtual Gallery project, where students will begin to collect and recontextualize images using a Canva whiteboard. Students will be asked to begin looking ahead and to feel free to start dropping images onto their whiteboards. Students should feel uninhibited in their selections, relying on instinct in the beginning. Concept, and narrative can be teased out later. Simply respond to culture, and images that speak to them.
	The teacher will present the whiteboard they have already created as an example and describe some of the choices that were made. Students are invited to ask questions.
Body of Lesson	By learning about artists of color who have used mythology in their work to imagine and create alternative realities and futures, students will develop insight into the relationship between mythology and reality and how oppressed communities have relied on mythology in the reproduction of culture as a tool for survival and healing.
	Students will be given the following discussion prompts to respond to in groups using Padlet: <i>Describe the significance of thread in Diedrick Brackens work (revisit the video if you need to). How might this relate to his identity as a queer Black man in America?</i> <i>How does Drexciya's nautical Afrofuturist mythology address the history of slavery?</i> <i>In your groups, try to come up with 3 things that would be different about your imagined/alternative futures or realities?</i> Students will also consider the meanings embedded in objects and material and how the manipulation of

Name of Lesson: Myth and Meaning-making or Culture in Freefall (Jafa)	
	context can tell vastly different stories about the same object.
Closure	The teacher will close the lesson by facilitating a 10-to-15-minute class discussion about objects and meaning, inviting the students to share examples of objects and what meanings are associated with them. The Teacher can provide the example of the meaning hoodies and Skittles took on after the murder of Trayvon Martin.
Assessment	The teacher will assess the students based on observations of discussion during group work and the Padlet responses the groups prepared. The teacher will look for: • Moments of intellectualism and criticality in the group discussions. • The clarity and detail with which the students have described their imaginings. • How is joy imagined in the utopian futures the students have illustrated?

Name of Lesson: <i>Curate: To Care</i>	
Teacher: Mr. Soublet	Grade Level: 11/12
Length of Lesson: 2 Weeks	
Students' Identities and Background: Predominantly Black and Brown, multiracial, multiethnic, multilingual students of varying learning abilities from challenged, low-resource communities.	
Learning Goals	Identities: The teacher will support the students in exploring and selecting works of art to include in their galleries. The teacher will encourage students to make inquiries into why

Name of Lesson: <i>Curate: To Care</i>	
	the pieces speak to them and how they relate to the students' identities. Skills: Students will be developing literacy skills through the creation of their curatorial texts and materials. This includes print and digital literacies across several modalities: writing, speaking, designing, audiovisual production, etc. Intellect: Students will experience firsthand how they are able to manipulate meaning and narrative by recontextualizing works of art to create new narratives. Criticality: Students will be curating their exhibits to respond to local issues that impact them directly. In being intentional about the work that they choose, and how they will present it, students will discover how accessibility, identity, power, and erasure are managed in the presentation of art. Joy: The creative act is an act of joy and love. This project is designed to inspire and unleash creativity, with healing and justice as central aims. If the student is not experiencing joy at any point in the project, then the that is an indication that the teacher must help the student identify why and plan for a new direction in which to pivot.
Layered Texts	SF MOMA: Zanele Muholi Exhibition Hammer Museum Guest Curator: Artist EJ Hill <i>"The latin root for the word curate comes from to care."</i> – EJ Hill
Vocabulary & Concepts	No vocabulary this lesson. Central concept is curation as caring. How will the exhibit bring joy and healing to a community.
Student Spark	

Name of Lesson: <i>Curate: To Care</i>	
	Students will be encouraged to explore multimodal curatorial materials by visiting the IG pages of art museums and institutions like the... • Studio Museum in Harlem • California African American Museum • The Hammer • SF MOMA • Art Gallery of Ontario And feeling free to get lost and go down rabbit holes of comments and links to other pages. While exploring students should be paying attention to the way art is written about and presented on social media or in museum catalogues. What concepts and ideas are commonly referred to? Do you find discussions about identity? Medium? Narratives? What is being said?
Body of Lesson	All of the learning up to this point will culminate here as students continue to develop and refine their virtual galleries using Canva whiteboards. Images are to be sourced from internet (right click, <i>save image as...</i>). Over the course of 5 class periods (1 week) the classroom will become a workshop where the teacher will collaborate with students (working in groups if they wish) to identify connections between the works they are selecting and how they respond to the issue or challenge they have chosen as the focus of the project. Before the end of the week, students will have decided on how they will be presenting their curatorial insights and analyses. The following are a few options they may choose from: • Write a small tour of your virtual gallery describing the connections between the pieces and why you chose them. Submit text and present live to class. • Write and record an audio tour to play for the class • Create a social media post announcing show (name?) – and include a caption for each piece

Commented [ac7]: The wisdom you have to encourage this - consider how you could use these processes to generate and ideate - why not have your students have a research journal. It can be helpful in all research endeavors and can help you identify any gaps in understanding students are experiencing about the sourcing process too.

Name of Lesson: <i>Curate: To Care</i>	
	Write a poem to be recited at opening gala (during class). Poem should be inspired by and articulate the themes and core ideas/statements of the show. Entering the second week of the lesson, the virtual gallery should be completed, and a modality through which to present the curatorial insights decided upon. Week 2 classroom workshop will be devoted to the authoring and production of the final projects.
Closure	Students will present their final projects to the class each followed by a brief QA/community conversation.
Assessment	Students' final projects will be assessed according to the following criteria which will have been provided to them prior to starting work on the project: Did the project "respond to the local"? In what ways would the exhibit deliver joy and care to the community? Did the student/group address this in their presentation? How did the student become smarter?

Eric,

I mentioned how moved I was by your unit already but this is nothing short of a work of Art! I am both inspired and reinvigorated by your unit. I firmly believe that you could use Art in this way to teach social studies across grade levels. You have curated a unit that could easily be a teaching style if you chose to do so. I have provided you some feedback, knowing that you are new to this field, that may help you envision your teaching in the same way you have given us a glimpse of in this unit. Engage with this feedback as you would a thinking partner and know that you did a wonderful job. None of the feedback is a criticism rather a collaboration. I am so excited for you to be in the classroom and step into your own and fullest self. Self-actualizing is a powerful experience, and I could not be more thrilled for you and the kids you will work with!

Feedback to further develop your unit:

As you consider this endeavor work towards integrating more historical contexts that illustrate the evolution of Black and Brown identities over time to deepen students' understanding. Encourage more personal connections. Students should have time and space to draw more personal connections between their identity and historical narratives. This could involve reflective writing or discussions about their family histories, community stories, or personal experiences with cultural institutions.

On this point consider how your overarching identity pursuit could be strengthened in this unit. Consider a goal that connects identity to personal and cultural narratives, encourages self-reflection and expression focus on empowerment and agency. Consider how this revised version of your goal further articulates the depth of what you are presenting in your unit plan and your aim of cultivating radical imagination and empowering students to construct new narratives that transcend societal limitations.

Note this is just an example not an exemplar: “Students will actively engage with and produce counternarratives through the study of art and mythology, allowing them to reflect on, express, and reshape their identities and personal stories. They will critically examine how their identities are portrayed in various media and create original works that challenge and expand these portrayals, empowering them to envision and articulate their own futures”

Do you identify the holistic and empowering approach to identity development within the goal and how it becomes evidenced in your plan? By making the goal more specific, personally relevant, and action-oriented, students are better positioned to explore and assert their identities in meaningful ways.

Continue to consider applications to the content area and content area goals. Consider how when you ensure the content area standards and content knowledge are met your instructional practices are less likely to be scrutinized. For example, emphasizing research skills by having students investigate the historical and social contexts of the artworks and myths they explore. This could include analyzing primary and secondary sources, which is a NYS Social Studies 9-12th grade common core standard.

On that note you touch on media bias and digital literacy skills but consider expanding this to be more explicit by teaching students how to critically evaluate the sources of digital images and information they use in their projects. This can include lessons on media bias, representation in digital media, and the impact of social media on public perceptions of history and culture.

I touched this point already but seek out ways to make connections between the arts and social studies by exploring how historical events and social movements have influenced

artistic expressions and mythologies. This could include studying specific time periods or movements (e.g., the Harlem Renaissance, the Civil Rights Movement) and their impact on art and culture but also include more local history content that connects directly to the students' community, allowing them to see their own place in the larger historical and cultural narrative.

Deepen the analysis of power dynamics in cultural representation by discussing how historical and contemporary curatorial practices have either reinforced or challenged dominant narratives. Encourage students to critique existing exhibitions and propose ways to make them more inclusive and representative.

Extend the discussion on how curation can impact local communities by involving students in projects that engage directly with their community. This could include collaborating with local museums or galleries, or creating exhibitions that are displayed in community centers or online platforms accessible to their community.

Hit joy home in a big way by considering inviting students' families in for a viewing of their culminating assignment and even giving space for families to engage in discussion around the work.

You will have many opportunities to build on this lesson plan at Warner. In your next iteration layer in content goals such as common core and/or next gen standards , consider an instructional goal for yourself (a practice I have gotten in the habit of and found VERY helpful in setting myself up for success). Consider the class time you will invest in each area of the lesson. Consider the ways that you will record the formative assessments throughout your unit and consider how the outcomes of those formative assessments will inform the direction of your unit too.

Best of luck to you on this new chapter of your life and career.